

Moonsea Rising - 20240406

Dark Thoughts

As Beitris tries to compose Harken's corpse, Taevyn pops the invisibility ring off his finger and slips in his pocket, looking slightly guilty in the process.

Lennox begins butchering the eel, looking for pieces of value. Lirael asks if they have any way to protect Harken's corpse until their return. Beitris protects him with Lathander's blessings, and they shut the doors behind themselves to hopefully keep him whole. The party licks their wounds, both physically and spiritually, before they head further to the south.

At the end of the corridor is a door with "this way," written in common. Behind it is a ten-by-ten room with four doors on each a wall, and an arrow on the floor made of rocks and shells. It says, "getting closer," and while Lirael is in favor of following the only direction they have until proven false, Beitris has a bad feeling about it. She asks Taevyn to check the other doors first.

He finds the eastern one locked. Without any tools to hand, Lennox shoulders his ax and begins awkwardly chopping through it underwater. Taevyn levels the ring of the dark sun at it, and it is blasted to flinders, floating away.

A stairs leading into a jumbled rockfall grace the middle of the room. In the weeds to the south, something furtive moves in the weeds. It swishes forward as Lennox bellows defiance at it, and Taevyn struggles with his crossbow. A draconic turtle, clearly surprised by Lennox's yell, swims towards Lennox, raking him with its claws repeatedly, and snapping its jaws on the big man.

Lirael takes in the scene. The turtle looks sickly, but still strong, and its shell is thick. It doesn't look like it can clear the doorway, however. Calling to Lennox to flee the room, she casts a web of sticky vines at the thing, snaring it. Taevyn instead dives around the thing, lashing out with his rapier and scoring a savage slash across an exposed leg. Floating in place, he raises his rapier to ward off an retaliation.

Beitris steps forward, healing Lennox for most of the damage done. Lennox lashes out with his ax, landing a serious blow to the creature. Frenzied by its wounds, it lashes out at Taevyn, hitting him with a claw, but exposing its neck on its bite. Taevyn tries to take advantage, but the turtle snaps its head back, the blow glancing off his shell. Lirael renews her vines, but the thing is only slowed, not immobilized.

Taevyn stabs with the rapier again, killing the beast. Lirael notices a message scratched in the wall beside the door to the turtle's room. Wiping away some lichens, she finds, "B, L, T, don't go through locked door; very large turtle."

Beitris immediately thinks the message is intended for them. Lirael is skeptical, but as they themselves are misplaced in time, perhaps others are as well. The turtle could have been quite ancient, but the inscription looked hundreds of years old.

Deciding that perhaps the inscriptions are in their favor, they follow the door out of the room. Finding another hallway with a door at the far end that says, "here", they move to it and open it.

Harken's Return

In the room, they find a giant octopus, floating above the grasses, holding a human skull. As Taevyn's eyes widen, Lirael addresses it in thalassic.

"Who are you?"

"Not who I am. Who this is!"

"Well, who is it?"

"I have a friend of yours."

She reaches out for the skull, and Harken's voice speaks in her mind.

He tells her he's been trapped here for over 220 years, bound to the skull (his, he claims), which the octopus is holding. Taevyn asks if he has the artifact, which Harken does not, though he knows a safe path, but for the final guardian, a fearsome kraken living in a deep shaft at the south of the complex.

Lirael sense Gruumsh's magic in the skull. She asks Harken if he knows how he came to be bound to the skull. He doesn't know for sure, but he believes it to have been Gruumsh's intervention. General Tuskclaw pipes up in her brain, telling her he also senses Gruumsh's hand in this.

She tells Harken that his body is nearby, despite his personal temporal issues. But, perhaps, they should retrieve the Lathandrite artifact and perhaps the power of the two gods will be able to restore him further.

The octopus, Karl, thanks Harken for his companionship but releases him to his friends. Karl tells her that this Harken is not the one that goes with the body they left behind. Lirael thanks him for the aid he has rendered, and after collecting some gems Harken has gathered over the centuries, they take their leave.

The Well

As Harken leads them to the deep pit he knows as The Well, Lirael asks him about his ability to interact with the physical world. He tells her he has some limited ability to use his telekinesis, but it's taxing. Beitris stops them, however, suggesting they return to the surface to prepare for a dangerous combat. Harken redirects, and leads them back towards the surface, where they find the ochre jelly blocking their path. It starts ungulping towards them.

Beitris notices it first, and fires a crossbow bolt at it, but it has limited effect. As Taevyn braces for it to reach them, Lennox rushes forward, charging the creature, battering it with the flat of his axe.

The jelly lashes out with a pseudopod, battering and burning him with its acid, and wrapping it around him. Taevyn fires his crossbow, whose cold magicks seem to affect it somewhat, as Lirael

blasts it with a ray of frost, cracking it in several places.

Harken reaches out his hand to it, and the jelly starts breaking apart, streams of it roiling into his incorporeal form. Lirael's eyes narrow as she recognizes the death magicks he's using, and wonders what it portends.

Lennox swings the axe sideways again, crushing the jelly despite the water resistance. Surface-side, they heal up and find a place to bed down, along the shoreline.

Returning to the well, they find a door with a glowing keyhole. Harken knows the well is behind the door, but he doesn't know where the key is. Beitris thinks the runes around the door resemble ancient Lathandrite script, but she's unable to read it. She recites an ancient prayer to Lanthander, which causes the door to begin streaming corruscating lights. A purple glow in the shape of her holy symbol draws her eye, and she places hers in it. The door vanishes.

Down a hallway, a giant sea creature is lurking. It looks badly injured, and swims out of their sight as soon as the door opens.

Harken addresses it in thalassic, and it tells them they will die if they come to retrieve the ring it guards. Beitris is confused, as her vision was of a jeweled dagger.

As they discuss what to do, Lennox and Taevyn think about the best way to attack the creature. Harken tells it they are prepared to die. The water fills with poisonous ink, causing those still breathing to choke and gag.

In the inky blackness, the creature swims up and bludgeons Lennox badly. He swings at it, but the giant beast is slippery and he cannot see. Gagging, Taevyn retreats from the room into the hallway.

Lirael mentally looks at the General, and closes her remaining eye. In the darkness, the kraken's curious voice rings out, "what is your command, my master."

Lirael speaks, her voice harsh. "Retreat. We must see what is in the well."

The sea horror recedes into the dark of its room, and the ink clears. Lirael's legs go weak, and she begins retching. As Beitris moves to the party, clensing the poison and healing everyone up, she pushes herself weakly upright again. However, the poison continues to act. Beitris clears it from Lennox, and the man straightens. As she works to remove it from herself, Lirael collapses, vomit erupting from her mouth as her body goes limp. As Harken stabilizes her, Beitris removes her poison as well, healing up herself and the others again.

As Lirael's remaining eye opens, Taevyn asks her how long her spell on the creature will last. Groggily, she responds that it should last long enough for their purposes. Tuskclaw speaks in her mind, "Good thing you're back, I cannot hold this thing back without you as a focus."

In the depths of the well, they do, in fact, find the jeweled dagger they expected. Beitris lifts it reverantly. Lirael, looks on, her skin pale, single eye glittering like an emerald.